

Role/Country: Pierre De Brazza
Committee: Berlin Conference
Topic: Race for Africa

Luna Rigüero

Background

Following the Industrial Revolution, there was intense competition between major European powers who strived to colonize Africa and reap its valuable resources before any other country. In an attempt to collaborate instead of waging countless wars for the fertile African lands, the European powers of United Kingdom, France, Germany, Austria, Belgium, Denmark, Spain, the United States of America, Italy, the Netherlands, Portugal, Russia, Sweden-Norway, and Turkey (Ottoman Empire) formed the Berlin Conference in Berlin, Germany.

The Conference was headed by Germany's Chancellor Otto von Bismarck who called for the negotiations with the intention of settling European disputes and doubts, as well as preventing further conflict between Great Britain and France, for territorial claims and commerce in Africa. The Berlin Conference's duration was from November 1884 to February 1885. By the end of the Conference, the countries reached an accord on the divisions in Africa, with an emphasis on the Congo River Basin in Central Africa. Additionally, according to Britannica, the countries "declared the Congo River basin to be neutral," which was significant because it "guaranteed freedom for trade and shipping for all states in the basin; forbade slave trading; and rejected Portugal's claims to the Congo River estuary." The rejection of Portugal's claim allowed for the Congo Free State to be founded as a colony of Belgium King Leopold II.

International Involvement

The Berlin Conference was an international effort to divide up Africa into areas where independent states and colonies could be established by European countries. However, the Berlin Conference failed to specify any distinct territorial claims other than Germany's claim of the area that became the Congo Free State and the Congo River Basin. Nonetheless, it did legitimize African colonization for European countries and drove international intrigue in Africa, although it itself did not initiate the colonization. Also, it set the framework for future partitioning of Africa, requiring countries to alert the other of any claims they made in order to avoid doubts and conflict.

Country Policy

As a colonial administrator and experienced explorer, I, Pierre de Brazza, have agreed to expand French territory in Africa on the behalf of France. France has implemented several policies and suggested strategies in order to effectively complete our mission while avoiding conflict with expanding European countries and West African leaders alike. France plans on assimilating West Africans, peacefully folding them into French culture and teaching them French values, as well as teaching them education and religion. France will even offer citizenship rights if they fulfill specific requirements. France plans on working through trade and negotiations with local chiefs to take the area without rebellion and benefit them as well with flourishing commerce, and benefit France with African resources. Lastly, France has decided to rule directly in Africa in order to further assimilate them into French life and allow the shift to mirror France more directly.

France and I urge the delegation to compromise to find solutions to avoid waging wars between colonial powers while still being beneficial to all, and France will do everything to respect boundaries agreed upon in counsel.

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